seats the ANP could have won.[56] In effect this reduced the electoral contest in the Rakhine to a fight for the ethnic Rakhine vote between the ANP, the RNDP and the NLD. The ANP makes much both of its Buddhist heritage and of the fact that Rakhine has been left as a poor and impoverished province by the ethnic Burmese governments that have ruled since independence. The NLD is described by the ANP as being 'pro-Muslim' and sympathetic to the Rohingyas while the USDP is seen to embody years of state neglect.[57] In this sense the NLD is suffering for standing up to the Buddhists extremists over the recent laws banning inter-marriage between Muslims and Buddhists.[58] As a result, when she visited Rakhine as part of the campaign, Aung San Suu Kyi deliberately avoided the regions where the Rohingyas lived and, of course, avoided any mention of their plight.

Despite its advantages, infighting within the ANP, combined with an electoral challenge from the rump of the RNDP, seems likely to reduce its influence in the next parliament, as many Rakhine will probably opt to vote for the USDP or NLD instead.[59] Whether or not this is good news for the Rohingyas is less clear. It is quite likely that, in an attempt to shore up waning support, the party will become even more extreme, as Aye Maung seeks to achieve his goal of becoming minister of Rakhine State.[60] In advance of the 2015 elections it was hard to know whether him succeeding in this aim (and thus having no constraint on his actions by the state administration) or failing (and perhaps seeking to create support by agitating for further violence and forced deportations) would have been the worse outcome for the Rohingyas. In the event, he lost his seat in parliament, making the future stability of Rakhine even less certain. One possibility is that, having been defeated electorally, the extremists will seek to bolster their support by further attacks on the Rohingyas.

Alternatively, this defeat may indicate that many Rakhine have turned their backs on the extremists. At the moment, the chief minister of Rakhine State, Maung Maung Ohn, is not an ethnic Rakhine (something that has annoyed the extremists) and has played a small but important role in controlling the Rakhine extremists.[61] Again, this points to the complexities of the situation, but also to just how much the current persecution of the Rohingyas is a political construct. They are still, as they have been since the late 1960s, a target of convenience.